

SNHU Travel Sprint Review and Retrospective

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As Scrum Master for the SNHU Travel project, I led the team's final Sprint Review and Retrospective. Across the project I also served as Product Owner, developer, and tester. SNHU Travel built a destination recommendation tool, starting with a Top Five Destinations feature and growing toward personalized, filterable results. This retrospective reviews how the roles, user stories, and Scrum events carried that work forward, how the team absorbed two changes in direction, and whether Scrum-Agile was the right fit.

Applying Roles

The project succeeded because each role carried a distinct responsibility and those responsibilities connected. As Product Owner, I was accountable for the backlog and for maximizing the value delivered (Schwaber & Sutherland, 2020), and I turned focus group input into six prioritized user stories, each sized large, medium, or small. The developer built those stories into the Top Five Destinations feature, showing a name, description, photo, and package link for each location. The tester derived test cases from the acceptance criteria, treating them as the basis for every pass or fail measure (International Software Testing Qualifications Board, 2023). As Scrum Master, I removed blockers and set communication guidelines in the charter. The roles worked as a system: the “Picked for You” label began as an acceptance criterion, became a verification step for the tester, then a build requirement for the developer.

Completing User Stories

A Scrum-Agile approach gave each story a path from idea to done. The “As a user, I want a task, so that I reach a goal” format kept the team focused on user value, and sizing let us prioritize before committing (Atlassian, 2023). Acceptance criteria were the hinge, because each bullet defined what done looked like in a checkable way. The Top Five Destinations story shows

this: its criteria called for an ordered list with a name, description, picture, and package link for each destination, and the application shipped with exactly those attributes for Paris, Bali, Santorini, Machu Picchu, and the Serengeti. Refinement and sprint planning turned vague stories into buildable ones before each sprint.

Handling Interruptions

The project changed direction twice, and both times the approach absorbed the change rather than breaking under it. First came a presentation shift: the Product Owner delivered a “Top Five Destinations SlideShow” wireframe that moved results from a scrollable list to slides with Previous and Next buttons. As tester, that single change invalidated every test case I had written, but because the work was sliced into small stories, I revised the affected cases at the next refinement instead of starting over.

The second change was larger. Management, citing an industry report that named detox and wellness travel the next major sector, asked the team to refocus the tool there. As developer, my task became re-theming the slideshow, not rebuilding it. The process absorbed it because the Product Owner reprioritized the backlog, so the team adapted without moving the deadline. The design absorbed it because the destination content lived in a separate data structure, apart from the methods that drew the screen, so I only swapped text and images. Responding to change over following a fixed plan was the difference between a short re-theme and a full rebuild.

Communication

Effective communication here meant specific questions, tied to a Scrum event, with a written record. While writing test cases, I emailed the Product Owner with numbered, closed questions a busy stakeholder could answer quickly:

Subject: Clarification Needed Before Finalizing Test Cases

(1) How is degree of match determined, and how many destinations should the slideshow show? (2) Does the budget limit apply to the per-person fare or the total package price? (3) For vacation types, should multiple selections use AND or OR logic? Please reply before Thursday's backlog refinement.

That worked because closed questions are easy to answer, it tied the request to an event, and it documented the decisions my test cases depended on. Starting the wellness pivot as developer, I wrote to both the Product Owner and the tester:

Subject: Information Needed to Begin the Detox/Wellness Sprint

Please confirm we are changing destination content only and keeping the existing navigation, and share a reprioritized backlog with acceptance criteria. Tester, please send updated test cases and test data so I build to the same definition of done you will verify. Could you both reply by Friday at noon?

That note encouraged collaboration by making each person's needed input explicit and setting one shared deadline, which kept the developer and tester from building and checking two different versions of the feature (Project Management Institute, 2021).

Organizational Tools and Scrum Events

The tools that helped most made work visible. The prioritized backlog, kept in a shared spreadsheet with detailed acceptance criteria, was the central organizing artifact, and a task board acted as an information radiator so anyone could see every story and its status. This supports transparency, a pillar of Scrum, because a team cannot inspect or adapt work it cannot see (Verwijns & Russo, 2023). A tool such as JIRA extends this into an always-on shared workspace. The tools mattered because the Scrum events turned their visibility into decisions: the board fed the Daily Scrum, where blockers surfaced; the backlog fed refinement and planning, where the slideshow and wellness questions were resolved; the working software fed the Sprint Review; and the Retrospective let the team inspect its process. The stand-up also built the psychological safety that makes people willing to raise a blocker at all (Rietze & Zacher, 2025).

Evaluating the Scrum-Agile Approach

Pros and Cons on SNHU Travel

The approach brought clear benefits to SNHU Travel. It absorbed two mid-project changes without derailing the schedule, kept every story tied to user value through acceptance criteria, and put working software in front of stakeholders early. It also had costs. It depended heavily on the Product Owner's availability, and when stories lacked detail, such as undefined data values or a missing no-results message, progress stalled until someone clarified them. The light documentation that keeps Agile fast also left gaps that surfaced late.

Was Scrum-Agile the Right Approach?

For this project, it was. SNHU Travel had requirements that were not fully knowable up front and that changed twice, which is exactly where Agile outperforms waterfall. A waterfall team would have treated the wellness pivot as a formal change request against a signed scope and schedule, costing time and likely money, while Scrum let the Product Owner reprioritize the backlog and adapt within the same cadence. The caveat is that Agile paid off only because communication and acceptance criteria stayed disciplined; where those slipped, its reliance on conversation became a liability.

Conclusion

Across every role I held, the same lesson held: Scrum worked because it kept the work visible, kept it tied to user value, and treated change as expected rather than exceptional. For SNHU Travel, whose direction shifted twice before release, that adaptability was the difference between adapting and stopping to renegotiate a plan.

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